industry committee decided to cancel the allotment of all 72 plots that were awarded to Sachan's Seema Shikshan Evam Samaj Sewa Sansthan and Abhinav Shiksha Evam Samaj Sewa Sansthan in 2012. Both institutes were also put on notice. Patel alleges Sachan used his "influence" as the Fatehpur MP to get the plots "secretly" allotted to his institutes. "The industrial development officials neither demarcated the industrial areas," he adds, "nor conducted spot visits while allotting the plots. This reeks of corruption."

The minister, however, calls the allegations "baseless", and puts the blame for irregularities on the industrial development department. "I was not even aware of these allotments," Sachan told INDIA TODAY. "The allotment documents name me, but there is no signature. My organisations did not even receive any allotment letter, through post or in person, in 2012." The minister claims that on February 15 itself—two days before Ajay Kumar Chaurasia, the deputy commissioner, industries, constituted a two-member inquiry panel—he had requested the industrial development department to cancel the allotment of all 72 plots in question.

The LBU report, which is being further probed by the industrial development and revenue departments, reveals that the UP State Industrial Development Corporation has a total of 367 plots in eight industrial areas in Fatehpur. Industries have been set up on only 101, or 28 per cent, of these plots. Even most of these units have shut down, leaving just 31 operational. With all plots at Chakhata and Sudhwapur lying vacant, locals claim they weren't even aware of the existence of industrial areas at these sites. The fact that the administration set up a gaushala on this industrial land further points to the poor state of affairs. But Anju Verma, the deputy collector at Bindki, reasons: "The gaushala has been set up on government land. Some of it was allotted to the industrial area, which will be freed soon."

Such administrative apathy apart, the initial inquiry also flagged procedural irregularities in the allotment of plots to Sachan's institutes. According to rules, if allottees fail to set up industrial units within a stipulated time, their allotment can be cancelled. Let alone scrap the allotment, the 10 officers who were posted as the deputy commissioner of industries, Kanpur, since May 2012 didn't even issue a notice to Sachan's institutes in all these years. The two-member inquiry panel has recommended action against all of them.

The whole episode has pushed the industrial development department to take stock of plots allotted across all industrial areas in the state. The data compiled so far reveals that there are 3,699 plots in the bigger industrial areas of the state. Out of these, only 25 are vacant. But, in mini industrial areas, as many as 1,551, or 20 per cent, of the 7,903 plots are lying vacant. This, at a time when government officials are scrambling for land to set up industries in the state. In the backward district of Sonbhadra, for instance, 82 companies had pledged Rs 1.25 lakh crore investments during the summit. But apparently there is no land available to set up mini industrial areas over five acres each in the four tehsils. "The government has been informed about the non-availability of land," says Ramdhari Gautam, the district's deputy commissioner, industries. "Further instructions are awaited."

Industrial development minister Nand Gopal Gupta says physical verification of land is under way across all industrial areas, and officers responsible for irregularities are being identified. "The inquiry is in its final stage. Action will be taken against the erring officials," he told INDIA TODAY. Fraudulently allotted plots or those lying vacant for long, he added, will be handed over to the new investors after completing all formalities. But what about Sachan? Mum's the word.

A political turncoat, Sachan left the SP to join the Congress in 2019 and then moved to the saffron fold ahead of the state elections last year. After winning from the Bhoganipur seat, he was awarded a cabinet berth and has remained in the news for all the wrong reasons. On August 8, days after the government withdrew four old cases against Sachan, much to the Opposition's chagrin, he was sentenced to one-year jail in a 32-year-old Arms Act case in Kanpur—becoming the first cabinet minister in the Yogi regime to be convicted in a criminal case.

Given the recent developments, it seems the government is going soft on him, yet again. "Sachan remains politically very relevant to the BJP," explains political scientist R.B. Tiwari of Kanpur University, "due to his influence over the Kurmi community in Kanpur Dehat, Fatehpur and surrounding districts." But with graft-free governance being crucial for creating an investment-friendly environment, can the Yogi government afford such cracks in its anti-corruption plank? ■

## TAKING STOCK

- As many as 1,551, or 20 per cent, of the 7,903 plots in the UP's mini industrial areas are lying vacant
- The bigger industrial areas are better-placed, with just 25 of the 3,699 plots vacant
- Physical verification is taking place after irregularities surfaced in the allotment of industrial plots in Fatehpur
- Factories were found to have been set up on only 101 of the 367 plots in the district's eight industrial areas
- The vacant plots included 72 allotted to two educational institutes of MSME minister **Rakesh Sachan** in 2012. The administration had set up a temporary gaushala on a part of this land five years ago.

